Meha Sadasivam

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Research areas

Climate Finance, Corporate Finance, Investments, Public Finance

Education

Columbia Business School — New York, NY
PhD in Finance — 2021 – Present
MS in Financial Economics — 2021

Birla Institute of Technology and Science, Pilani — Hyderabad, India
B.E. Electrical & Electronics Engineering — 2016

References

Kent Daniel
kd2371@columbia.edu

Jonathan Dingel
j.dingel@columbia.edu

Tano Santos (chair)
js1786@gsb.columbia.edu

Pari Sastry
psastry@wharton.upenn.edu

Stijn Van Nieuwerburgh
sgv2110@columbia.edu

Working Papers

The value and limits of local climate adaptation (Job Market Paper)
Center for Political Economy Grant (2026)
What are the returns to investment in flood protection, and how does the financing structure shape its provision? Studying Louisiana's levee districts, I estimate a triple-differences regression using observations along the boundaries of districts that passed the levee tax. Property values inside the district rise about 32% on average, and increase by 3% per additional foot below the levee. The gains reflect demand for protection: occupancy increases more in high exposure areas. The tax burden is much smaller than these gains, but levee referenda often fail. A key financing friction is that uneven benefits and uniform taxes can cause the median voter to oppose aggregate improvements. I develop a spatial model with heterogeneous flood exposure and risk-reduction investments to quantify the welfare cost of this friction and evaluate the financing limits of local climate adaptation.

Different shades of ESG funds — June 2026
with Simona Abis, Andrea Buffa
We classify US active equity mutual funds by the objective for which they use ESG information. Impact funds, incorporating non-pecuniary ESG preferences, manage under 5% of ESG assets; the remainder is overwhelmingly held by opportunity funds using ESG data for financial gain. Opportunity funds tilt only on financially material ESG dimensions and inflate their ESG exposure before disclosure dates. Impact funds, instead, tilt toward firms generating positive impact, show no greenwashing or window dressing, avoid firms committing ESG violations, and use shareholder voice to advocate for better environmental and social outcomes. ESG funds cannot be treated as a monolithic category.

Extreme weather and risk perception — June 2025
Bernstein & Tamer Centers' Joint Doctoral Research Grant (2023)

This paper examines how investors differentially update their climate risk perceptions following extreme weather events. Studying registered investment advisers' portfolio allocations, I document a significant shift toward safer assets (government bonds) and away from risky assets (equity) following local extreme weather disasters. The magnitude of this portfolio reallocation varies systematically with political ideology, a proxy for heterogeneous prior beliefs about disaster risk. Democratic counties exhibit the most persistent risk-off behavior when directly experiencing disasters, particularly during first-time exposures compared to subsequent events. The updating of beliefs also occurs through social networks, with the strongest effects observed in swing counties, where prior beliefs about disaster probabilities are less firmly anchored. These findings complement the literature that suggests political ideology plays a crucial role in how investors process climate risk information, and provides novel insights on the strength of each step in the belief updating process.

Work in progress

Climate risk transfer?
with Jack McCoy

Climate Innovation
with Caroline Flammer, Olivier David Zerbib

Research experience

RA for Pari Sastry	2024
RA for Jesse Schreger (Country Risk)	2020 – 2021
RA for Wei Jiang (Appraisal Arbitrage)	2019 – 2020

Teaching experience

Instructor, MS Math Bootcamp	2024
TA, MBA Capital Markets (Kent Daniel, Simon Oh)	2024 – 2026
TA, PhD Big Data and Finance (Harry Mamaysky, Michael Johannes)	2021 – 2024
TA, MBA Capital Markets (Suresh Sundaresan)	2022
TA, MBA Advanced Corporate Finance (John Moon)	2022
TA, MBA Debt Markets (Suresh Sundaresan)	2021
TA, PhD Computing for Business Research (Kriste Kristovski)	2020
TA, MS Python Bootcamp (Lira Mota)	2020

Conferences/ Workshops

MFR Modeling Climate Economic Dynamics Workshop	2026
NBER Climate Finance - PhD Workshop	2025
ARCS 2025 - PhD Workshop	2025
Princeton Initiative: Macro, Money and Finance	2023
Yale Summer School in Behavioral Finance	2022
Stanford Big-Data Initiative in International Macro-Finance	2021

Scholarships

Doctoral Fellowship (Columbia Business School)	2021 – 2026
Paul and Sandra Montrone Doctoral Fellowship	2021, 2024
50% Tuition Scholarship (Columbia Business School)	2019 – 2021

Work experience

Bank of America, Global Research	New York, NY
Summer Associate - ESG/ Quant Research	2020
D.E. Shaw & Co	Hyderabad, India
Software Engineer	2016 – 2019

	J.P. Morgan Junior Analyst Intern - M&A	Mumbai, India 2016
Service	PhD Seminar Organizer, Columbia Business School Admissions Committee, MSFE Program, Columbia Business School	2024 – 2025 2020 – 2023
Other activities	New York City Marathon	2023, 2025
Personal	Citizenship: United States Gender: Female	
Other information	GitHub: mehasadasivam LinkedIn: mehasadasivam	

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